



Grade 3
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 3 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

Read the passage.

How Flamingo Earned Her Pink Feathers

- 1 Long, long ago, Mother Nature asked the birds to visit her. She had special gifts for them to choose from. Flamingo, Crow, and Robin flew together to Mother Nature's home. Along the way, they passed Dragonfly, who was stuck in a spider web.
- 2 "Please help me!" Dragonfly pleaded. "I'm trapped."
- 3 "We promise to come help you later," Robin replied.
- 4 "We want to be first in line to choose our gifts," Crow added. Robin and Crow flew away, but Flamingo did not. Gently, she **untangled** the web and freed Dragonfly's wings. Then she flew to Mother Nature's home. But by the time she reached it, all but one gift had been chosen.
- 5 Flamingo watched Robin clean her new orange feathers. She listened to Crow sing about his new suit of shiny black feathers. Flamingo had hoped for pretty feathers too. Her wings were the color of dull sand. But all the gifts of colorful feathers had been chosen by the other birds.
- 6 The only gift Mother Nature had left was a big, bent beak. Its bottom was larger than its top. With a sigh, Flamingo accepted the beak. Then she slipped down by the lake to hide.
- 7 Before long, Dragonfly appeared. He hovered around Flamingo and **inspected** her beak.
- 8 "Your beak has a different shape," Dragonfly observed. "Perhaps it can do something unusual."
- 9 Flamingo decided to find out what her new beak could do. She lowered her head into the water until it was upside down and moved it from side to side. To her surprise, her beak filled with water and tasty shrimp! It was such a treat for Flamingo to feast on shrimp.
- 10 By evening, Flamingo had eaten her fill of shrimp. In fact, she had eaten so much shrimp that her feathers had turned a beautiful shade of pink. When Robin and Crow came to the lake for a drink, they were surprised.
- 11 "Where did you get such beautiful pink feathers?" Robin asked.
- 12 "You look like the setting sun!" Crow complimented.
- 13 "Thank you," Flamingo replied as she smiled at Crow.

1. From whose point of view is the story written?

- A. Narrator
- B. Flamingo
- C. Dragonfly
- D. Mother Nature

2. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

What does Crow do when Dragonfly asks the birds for help?

- A. Crow goes to the lake for a drink of water.
- B. Crow tells Flamingo to help while he flies ahead.
- C. Crow worries about his new feathers and goes home.
- D. Crow chooses to leave so he can get something good.

Part B

Which detail from the passage supports the answer to Part A?

- A. Crow watches as Flamingo helps Dragonfly.
- B. Crow says that he wants to be first to pick a gift.
- C. Crow sings proudly about his shiny black feathers.
- D. Crow talks with Robin about helping Dragonfly later.

3. **Read this sentence from the story.**

“Gently, she **untangled** the web and freed Dragonfly’s wings.”

Based on the prefix **un-**, what does the word **untangled** mean in the sentence?

- A. full of knots
- B. pulled apart
- C. able to twist
- D. twisted again

4. How does Flamingo feel when she first receives her gift?

- A. disappointed with the beak
- B. angry about helping Dragonfly
- C. excited that she got something new
- D. happy that Robin got colorful feathers

5. **Read these sentences from the story.**

“Before long, Dragonfly appeared. He hovered around Flamingo and **inspected** her beak.”

What does **inspected** mean in the story?

- A. flew slowly
- B. looked carefully
- C. left immediately
- D. arrived suddenly

6. How does Flamingo first find out that her beak is special?
- A. Robin asks about Flamingo’s new beak.
 - B. Flamingo catches shrimp with her beak in the lake.
 - C. Mother Nature explains the beak’s purpose to Flamingo.
 - D. Flamingo smiles with her beak after Crow says kind words to her.
7. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

What is the central lesson of the story?

- A. Picking good things brings happiness.
- B. Being first can lead to the best things.
- C. Being kind can lead to surprising rewards.
- D. Following others is better than going alone.

Part B

Which detail from the story BEST supports the answer to Part A?

- A. Flamingo flew to Mother Nature’s home after the others.
- B. Flamingo waited quietly by the lake after receiving her gift.
- C. Flamingo watched Robin clean her new bright orange feathers.
- D. Flamingo’s feathers turned pink after eating shrimp with her new beak.

8. Why did the author MOST LIKELY write the story?
- A. to consider a science topic
 - B. to make people study birds
 - C. to inform about the eating habits of birds
 - D. to explain where something in nature comes from

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 9. Read the story that LeAnn is writing.

Jessie was having a hard morning. First, she could not find her homework. She looked under the bed, in her backpack, and even in the kitchen. At last, she found it under the couch. Then she looked at the clock. She ran out the door to catch her bus. Just then, she heard a loud rip. A tree branch had torn her favorite coat. Jessie saw the bus up the street. She was going to miss it! Jessie ran as fast as she could. She got to the stop just in time. Jessie sat down in the seat and sighed. She hoped her day would get better soon.

LeAnn wants to add a word to the beginning of the underlined sentence.

Which word should LeAnn use?

- A. Later, Jessie saw the bus up the street.
- B. Earlier, Jessie saw the bus up the street.
- C. Second, Jessie saw the bus up the street.
- D. Suddenly, Jessie saw the bus up the street.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 10. Read the sentence Tanya wrote.

I enjoyed reading the book *Julian and the brave horse*.

What is the correct way to capitalize the book's title?

A. *Julian And The Brave Horse*

B. *Julian and The brave horse*

C. *Julian and the brave Horse*

D. *Julian and the Brave Horse*

- ★ 11. Select the transition that BEST completes the sentence.

Likewise,

To begin with,

In the meantime,

Most importantly,

Dear Mom and Dad,

Now that I am in third grade, I think you should let me ride my bike to school with Joaquin. _____ I am responsible enough to leave for school on time. I always lock my bike to the rack, and I never lose my key. Joaquin and I ride safely. We would ride on Lincoln Street, where there is less traffic. Best of all, it would save you time in the morning because you would not have to drive me. Please consider my idea.

Your daughter,

Cherise

Read the passage.

Let's Go Fly a Kite!

- 1 Many people look forward to afternoons when the wind is just right. Tree leaves rustle, grass sways, and flags flap in the breeze. This is perfect weather for kite flying. People who fly kites can enjoy fresh air, exercise, and fun. Kite flying also offers another surprise. It's a chance to take part in an activity that has been happening for thousands of years in many parts of the world.

The History of Kites

- 2 Kites have been around for more than 2,000 years! The first kites were most likely flown in China. One legend tells about a Chinese farmer who tied a string to his hat on a windy day. When his hat blew up into the air, the first kite was created.
- 3 Over time, people in different countries started to fly kites. Many kites had special purposes. Some gave signals so armies knew where to march. Others dropped bait into the water so fishermen could catch more fish.
- 4 Later, kites became popular as children's toys. However, kites still did some important jobs. Many years ago, a weather scientist used a kite to send a thermometer 3,000 feet into the sky. This way, the scientist could measure the temperature there. Benjamin Franklin used a kite to discover that lightning was a kind of electricity. Space scientists also used kites to find spacecrafts that had returned to Earth.

Serious Fun

- 5 Today, people enjoy flying kites for fun. Kite contests are also very popular. For some contests, people try to build the most interesting kites. For others, people try to fly kites high and far. Sometimes the kite flyer tries to make the kite do tricks in the air. The best kites and flyers compete in world championships.
- 6 Some kites that have won contests have unusual shapes. They may look like a dragonfly, a spaceship, or a bee. Often, kites are covered with beautiful colors and pictures.

How Kites Fly

- 7 One of the reasons kites can fly is that they are light. This helps them get off the ground. Kites must also be **sturdy**. They need to keep their shape even when the wind is blowing strong.
- 8 A kite that has a tail flies better. This tail adds weight to the kite. When the wind blows, it blows the tail. This makes the kite point toward the wind and stay in the air. Without a tail, the kite might spin and roll.

- 9** Of course, a kite must have a string. The person who flies the kite holds tightly to it. Without the string, the kite would blow away. The string can also help the flyer get the kite into the air. If there is not much wind, the flyer can hold onto the string and run. Before long, the kite will be **soaring**! The string also helps the flyer control the direction the kite moves.
- 10** If you want a fun activity that has been around for a long, long time, go fly a kite!

12. Which **two** ideas from the passage show how kites have been used to help people?
- A. Kites were used as children's toys.
 - B. People entered kites in competitions.
 - C. Kites were used to find the temperature.
 - D. Kites have been around for over 2,000 years.
 - E. Kites signaled armies to know where to march.
13. What does **sturdy** mean as it is used in paragraph 7?
- A. fun
 - B. large
 - C. special
 - D. strong
14. How do the headings help the reader understand the passage?
- A. The headings provide the key terms used in the passage.
 - B. The headings organize the events of the passage in order.
 - C. The headings provide the main idea of each section of the passage.
 - D. The headings provide details about the activities discussed in the passage.

15. What does **soaring** mean as it is used in paragraph 9?

- A. flying high
- B. moving quickly
- C. changing shape
- D. winning contests

16. According to the passage, what must a kite have?

- A. a tail
- B. a string
- C. a strong wind
- D. a regular shape

17. Write the letter for each sentence in the chart to show the ideas found in each section from the passage.

A. Kites are light and often have a tail.

B. People have been flying kites for a very long time.

C. Some people fly kites in contests.

The History of Kites	
Serious Fun	
How Kites Fly	

18. What is the author's main purpose for writing the passage?

A. to persuade the reader to fly a kite

B. to explain to the reader how kites stay in the sky

C. to entertain the reader with a story about people flying kites

D. to inform the reader about the history of kites and how to fly them

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 19. A student is writing a research report about popcorn. His research question is “What is the history of popcorn?”. He took the following notes.

Which note BEST supports the research question?

- A. Without added butter, popcorn can be a healthy snack.
- B. Popcorn can easily be made on a stove or in a microwave.
- C. Many people celebrate National Popcorn Day on January 19.
- D. By the 1840s, popcorn was a very popular snack in the United States.

- ★ 20. **Read the sentence.**

Juan and Jared _____ quickly to the playground as they wave to their cousin.

Which word completes the sentence?

- A. jog
- B. jogs
- C. jogged
- D. jogging

**NSCAS General Grade 3
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points						
1	A	1						
2	Part A: D Part B: B	2						
3	B	1						
4	A	1						
5	B	1						
6	B	1						
7	Part A: C Part B: D	2						
8	D	1						
9	D	1						
10	D	1						
11	To begin with,	1						
12	C, E	2						
13	D	1						
14	C	1						
15	A	1						
16	B	1						
17	<table><tr><td>The History of Kites</td><td>People have been flying kites for a very long time.</td></tr><tr><td>Serious Fun</td><td>Some people fly kites in contests.</td></tr><tr><td>How Kites Fly</td><td>Kites are light and often have a tail.</td></tr></table>	The History of Kites	People have been flying kites for a very long time.	Serious Fun	Some people fly kites in contests.	How Kites Fly	Kites are light and often have a tail.	1
The History of Kites	People have been flying kites for a very long time.							
Serious Fun	Some people fly kites in contests.							
How Kites Fly	Kites are light and often have a tail.							
18	D	1						
19	D	1						
20	A	1						